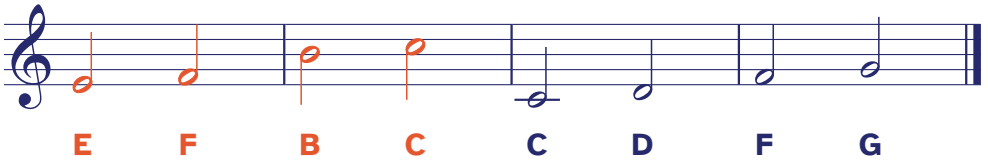
PART I · PITCH · 7

Counting intervals

The smallest step on the piano is a **semitone**: from one key to the very next. Two semitones make a **tone**. Bigger distances are **intervals**: to give one a number, **count the notes**, both ends included.

THE SECRET

The very next key is a semitone; two make a tone. For an interval, count the notes, both ends included.



E–F and B–C: next door, a semitone. C–D and F–G: a black key between, a tone.

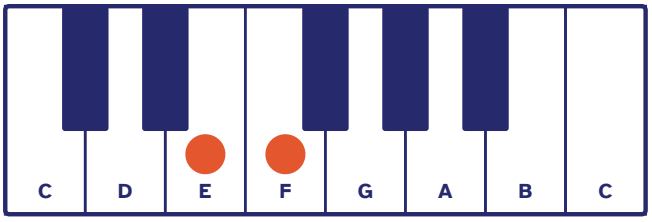
From any key to the **very next key**, black or white, is a **semitone**: the smallest step on the piano. Two semitones make a **tone**. On the white keys most steps are tones, but **E–F** and **B–C** have no black key between them: they are semitones.

THE RULE

Semitone: the very next key, with nothing between: white to white (E–F, B–C), white to black, or black to white. Tone: exactly one key between.

EXAMPLE 1

Tone or semitone?

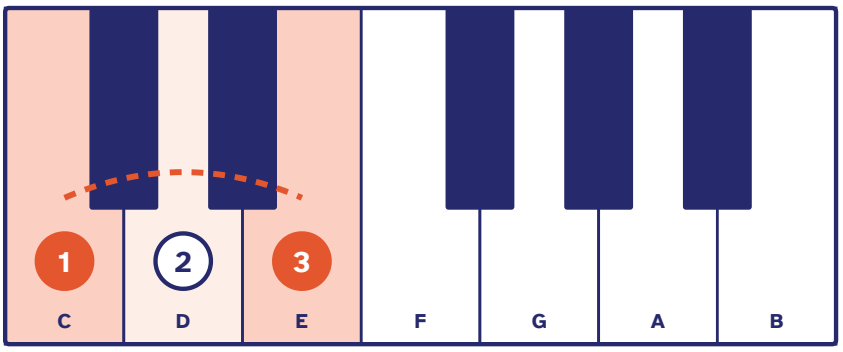


1. **Look between the red keys:** is there a black key?
2. **No black key** means they are next-door keys.
3. **Now try C and D**: is there a black key between?

E–F is a **semitone** (next door). C–D has C♯ between: a **tone**.

PART I · PITCH · 7 · CONTINUED

Intervals: count the notes



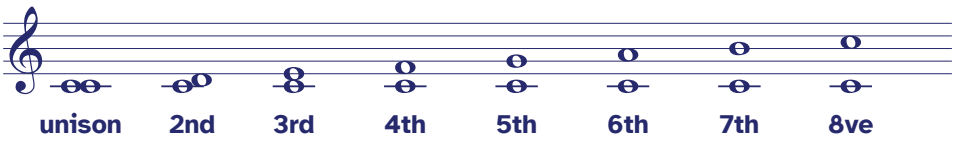
C to E: count the notes, 1 2 3: a 3rd

THE RULE

Count the letters for the number: start at 1 on the first note and count white keys, or lines and spaces, never the black keys. C to E is C D E: 3 notes, a 3rd. Sharps and flats never change the number.

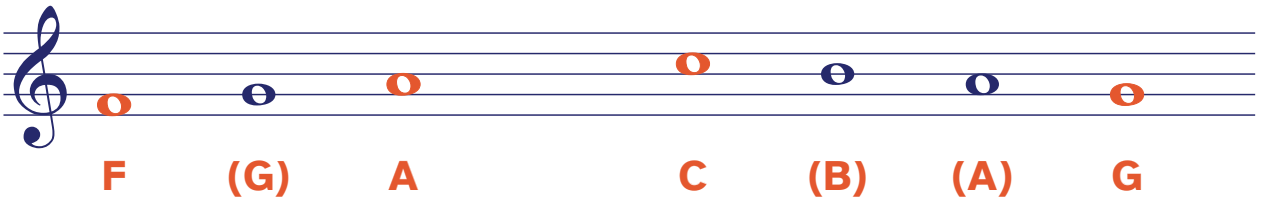
A step on the staff (the next letter) may be a tone (C–D) or a semitone (E–F); C to C♯ is a semitone with no new letter.

Interval numbers from C



EXAMPLE 2

How far apart are these notes?



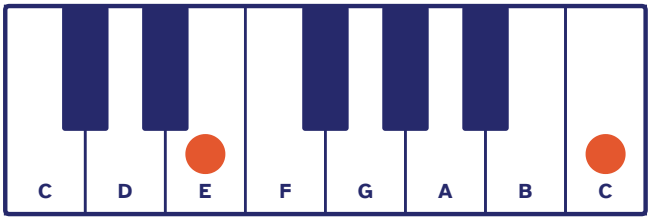
1. **Call the first note 1:** here F is 1.
2. **Count every letter** up to the second note.
3. **Going down works the same:** start at 1 on the top note and count down.

F G A is 3 notes: a **3rd**. C B A G is 4 notes: a **4th**.

PART I · PITCH · 7 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 3

Name an interval on the keyboard

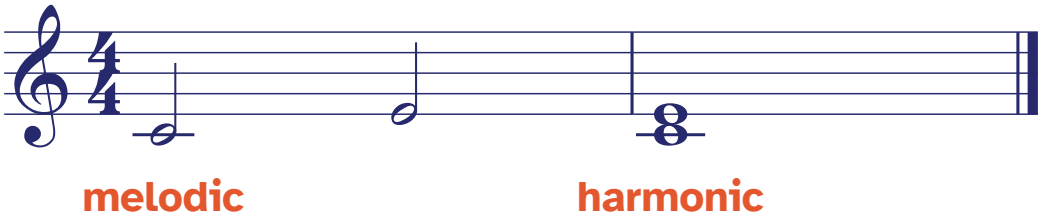


1. **Find both red keys:** E, and the C above it.
2. **Count the notes** from E: E is 1 …
3. **Stop on the C.** What number is it?

E F G A B C is 6 notes: a **6th**.

EXAMPLE 4

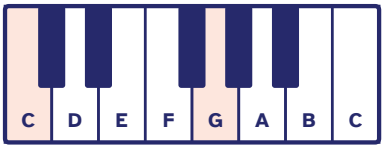
Melodic or harmonic?



1. **The first bar:** C, then E, one after the other.
2. **The second bar:** C and E at the same time.
3. **Count the notes** in each.

Both are a **3rd**: **melodic** when played one after the other, **harmonic** when played together.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Thumb on C, finger 5 on G.

Your hand is a ruler: thumb to little finger on white keys is a 5th. Play it, then thumb to finger 3: a 3rd.

TRAP

× Counting only the gaps: C to E is 3 notes, not 2 gaps. And a sharp or flat never changes the number: C to G♯ is still a 5th.

SEE ALSO
Major, minor and perfect p. 45 · Major scales p. 93

PRACTISE IT
Workbook Pitch 7 · Online: Intervals · Tones & Semitones